



## The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us.

Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in some belief a reason for doubt?

It seems that to find a reason for doubting a belief would be to be less than certain that the belief is true. But what things can we be certain of? One natural thought is that we can be certain only of those things that we can **prove**.

This suggests the following rule of belief:



Let's all believe which we've, but don't have any argument for, basic beliefs.

Then the key question seems to be: which basic beliefs should we have?

We all have a great number of basic beliefs: things that we believe about the world, but, if pressed, could not give good arguments for. Can you think of any examples?

One way to approach the question about which basic beliefs we should have is to ask how we can test our existing basic beliefs. Under what conditions should we discard one of these?

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?



investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us.

of virtues. Some are based on serious thought and



The start from scratch approach

out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety

nothing, and test all our beliefs against standard to

riod

of.

see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get

Some are based on what friends told us. Some are

probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure



taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume

which to keep, and which to discard?

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide



individuals just as fully as I do from those which are

assent from opinions which are not completely certain and

'Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my

patiently false. So, the purpose of rejecting my opinion,



**doctors**

it will be enough if I find in each then one reason for

that we can prove.

of? One natural thought is that we can be certain only of those things

It seems that to find a reason for doubting a belief would be less

that certain that the belief is true. But what things can we be certain

Let's all believe which we've, but don't have any argument for, basic beliefs.

We all have a great number of basic beliefs: things that we believe about the



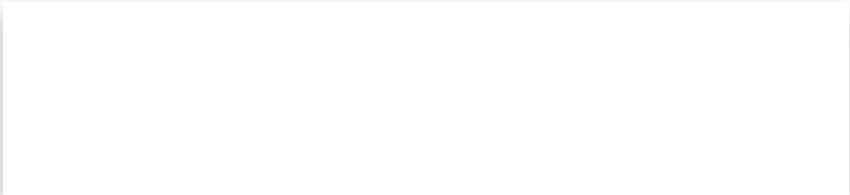
world, but, if pressed, could not give good arguments for. Can you think of any

examples?

ask how we can test our existing basic beliefs. Under what conditions should we

One way to approach the question about which beliefs we should have is to

discarded one of these?

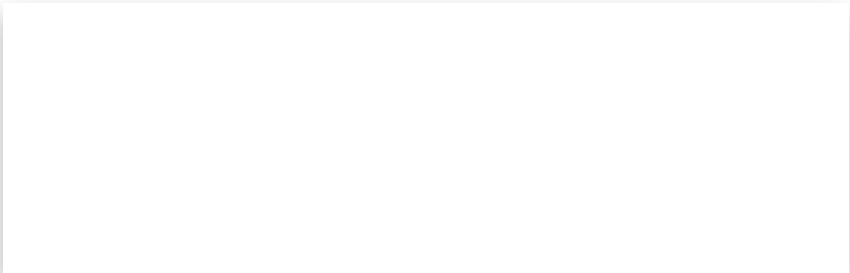


What should I believe?

if you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-

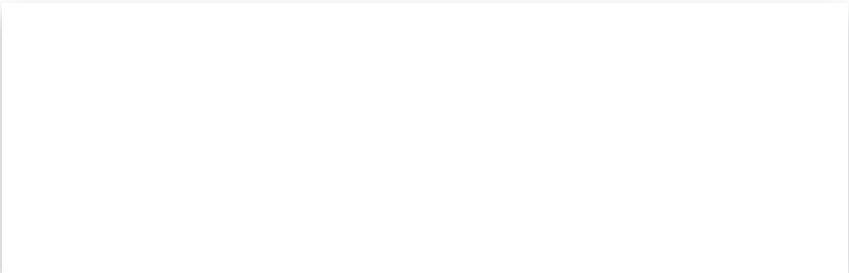


questions.



What should I find a

never die?



When should I discontinue

one of my beliefs?

Positive rules of belief will tell you



when you should form a certain

berief.









berief.

when you should not have a certain



Negative rules will tell you









It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The

following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive

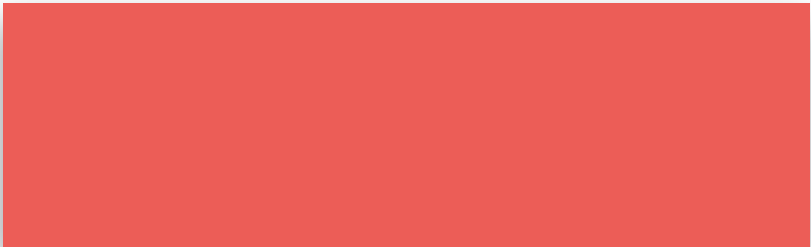
and negative rules of belief.















the belie.f.)

false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form



problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in

many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the









We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules



by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.

in which there are arguments on both sides of an issue, and where it is

hard to tell which argument is better?

what we should believe. In fact, you might think, philosophy is a kind of



machine for generating hardware! Haven't yet already seen lots of cases

Why would we want to do this? Well, face cases where it is not clear

Here is a hard case of interest:





I've always believed that there is a God. I never

arguments for God's existence and god, but

exits.

THE BILIVER

this claim. But now I wonder whether I have

good reason for my beliefs. Some of the

really thought about what my evidence is for

answer. Still, I continue to believe that God



all face objects that I can not see how to

It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And

but what the rules of belief are.

it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure



When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?

When should I discard  
one of my beliefs?